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D.C.'S FORGOTTEN CEMETERY: MT. ZION FEMALE UNION BAND CEMETERY'S STRUGGLE WITH REMEMBRANCE AND ITS OWN TURBULENT HISTORY

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Abstract

- This senior thesis looks at issues of race, memory, and historical preservation of sacred spaces. Mt. Zion Female Union Band Cemetery is a historic cemetery in Georgetown, located on 27th Street and Mill Road. It is a biracial cemetery, with historic ties to the Underground Railroad, where many influential members of the African American Community of Georgetown are buried. For decades, members of the Mt. Zion Church and the African American community that made up Georgetown kept this historic cemetery clean and lively properly celebrating its history and the memory of those buried there. Over time, most of

the members of this community moved away for a multitude of reasons. Throughout the process of their dispersion, Mt. Zion Female Union Band Cemetery fell into a deep state of disrepair. This thesis argues that the disconnect between physical location of Mt. Zion-Female Union Band Cemetery and the dispersed community that would support this cemetery (as the final resting place of their ancestors) has led to its current state of disrepair; and, conversely, this disconnect has given urgency to the need for the site to be remembered and preserved. The urgency to remember and preserve increases every day that it continues to fall into disrepair and every day that the

connection between those buried here and their descendants becomes more tenuous. Official government documents, pictures of the site throughout the years, interviews regarding oral history, and court cases are utilized to analyze the implications of the disconnect between community and space.

Title

- D.C.'S FORGOTTEN CEMETERY: MT. ZION FEMALE UNION BAND CEMETERY'S STRUGGLE WITH REMEMBRANCE AND ITS OWN TURBULENT HISTORY

Creator

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Publisher

- [Georgetown University](#)

Date Created

- 2020-04-23

Date Issued

- 2020-04-23

Resource Type

- [Thesis](#)

Source

- [American Studies](#)

Keyword

- [Oak Hill Cemetery](#)
- [Georgetown](#)
- [Cemetery Gentrification](#)
- [Disrepair](#)
- [Memory](#)
- [Mt. Zion Female Union Band Cemetery](#)
- [African American Community of](#)
[Georgetown](#)
- [Remembrance](#)

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- English

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STRUGGLE WITH REMEMBRANCE AND ITS OWN TURBULENT HISTORY

A Senior Thesis
submitted to the Faculty of the
College of Arts and Sciences
of Georgetown University
in partial fulfillment of the requirements for the
degree of
Bachelor of Arts
in American Studies

By

Hannah K. Smulson

Washington, D.C.
April 23, 2020

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